would change my life and, to a great degree, alter the pace of India's space research, some nineteen years later.

As we walked past a few charts on display, between a heat shield of a rocket and a model of an improvised payload, there sat a rocket engine from the USSR. It was grey, and it had everything the texts said about such an engine. There was nothing apparently remarkable about it, but I found myself staring at it longer than I wanted to.

Then I realised it: The engine wasn't what its label read—RD-100. 'They've got the label wrong,' I told Prasad, as we were about to move on to the payload on display. But Prasad stopped to take closer look. We seemed to be having a difference of opinion here; so the first thing to do was to ask a Russian scientist for clarification. But there was none nearby. At a distance sat a seventy-five-something man, his clothes as wrinkled as his skin. He appeared to be a helper of some sort, one of those who understood little English and no science.

No sooner had we moved on than someone called out, 'Now, gentleman, what makes you think it's not an RD-100?'

It was the Russian, now his face even more wrinkled because of a frown. I walked up to him and, trying to be polite to the point of being apologetic (not for the comment I made about the engine, but for the assessment I made of him), said, 'Because it doesn't look like one.'

He insisted it was an RD-100, but I stuck to my guns. 'An RD-100 has a different type of a cooling passage,' I said, and went on rattling out whatever I knew about the engine and its inconsistencies with the piece on display.

The frown on the Russian's face was now a scowl. He looked at me for a few seconds in silence and, as if ironing out those folds on his forehead, ran his palm over his eyebrows, and assumed the calmness of a disturbed saint. 'Can we discuss this over dinner?' he asked.

Later that evening, over delicious French soup and bread, the Russian explained to us the specifications of the engine on display. 'And yes,' he said after a noisy sip of tourin, 'it is not what it's labelled.' It was another engine, the specifications of which the USSR did not want to divulge. There